

An Autistic Child in Your Class

For primary-school teachers & teaching assistants — supporting an autistic primary-school child (roughly ages 6–11).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a child's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." School — noisy, visually busy and full of transitions — is genuinely hard for many monotropic kids, *even the ones who love learning*. Resistance at change-over time is a **cognitive-cost** problem, not defiance. Protect their focus and their interests, lower the load, and you will usually see a keen, capable learner emerge.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Deep "obsession" with one topic; resists other work	A passion that's also the best bridge to <i>all</i> learning — not a distraction
Won't start, switch off, or pack up; "defiant" at transitions	Autistic inertia — changing track costs real energy
Meltdown or withdrawal at break, lunch, assembly	Unstructured, noisy time is often the hardest part of the day
Takes things literally; slow to answer; "not listening"	Single-channel, literal communication + processing time
"Fine" in class, collapses at home	Heavy masking all day — the cost is paid later

Try this

- **Make the special interest the spine of learning** — reading, writing, maths and topic work *through* it. This is one of the most powerful inclusion tools there is.
- **Predictability lowers the load**: visible timetable, "now / next" boards, warnings before every change, bridge objects between activities.
- **Protect focus and flow** — allow extended time on interest-led work; deep concentration *is* a learning state.
- **Provide a quiet, low-light place** (library job, calm corner) for break and for decompression; have a plan for overwhelm.
- **Give reasons, literally, one thing at a time**. "Why?" is engagement, not back-chat.
- **Talk with the child and believe them** about what's hard; co-create routines and supports.

Avoid this

- Using the interest only as a reward to withhold — it turns their main regulator into leverage.
- Insisting on eye contact or stillness as the price of respect; stopping them stimming or moving.
- Piling on verbal instructions, last-minute changes, or forced group work without preparation.

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** / “**regression**” — a sudden drop in skills usually means *overwhelm*, and the response is to reduce demands and restore rest and interests, not push harder. Liaise closely with **parents (the expert on their child)**, the **SENCO/SEND lead**, and any autism outreach team. Flag bullying and unstructured-time distress early.

If the child is a girl

Girls this age camouflage heavily and are often missed — the quiet, compliant, “anxious” child may be an exhausted autistic one. Take parental concern and subtle differences seriously.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 3), the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.2) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual child.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2019, *Monotropism at School*; 2023); Wood (2019, intense interests & inclusion); BERA (2021, flow in the classroom); Dwyer (2025); Edgar (2024, regression/burnout). Full citations are in the source drafts.